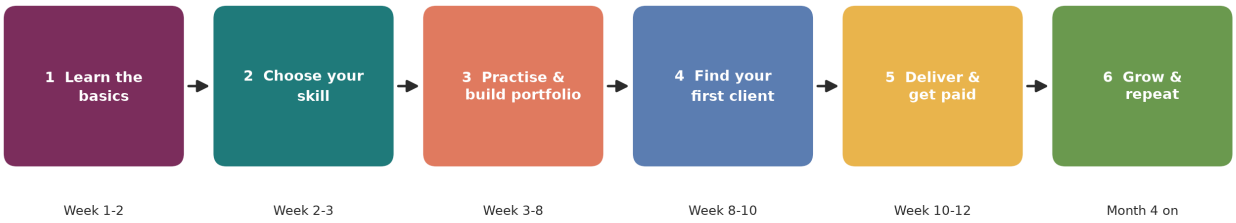
Digital Career Course

A beginner's guide for women working from home
to build a part-time digital career

Learn a skill for free. Build proof of your work. Find your first clients. Get paid safely, and grow at your own pace.

Your 12-week route to a first digital client



Written in English. No paid software or equipment required.

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Each chapter has a checklist. Do the actions before moving on.

CHAPTER 0

Welcome and How to Use This Course

This course is for women who work from home, have basic phone or computer skills, and want to earn from digital work in the hours they can spare. You do not need a degree, a computer science background, or any paid software.

What you will be able to do at the end

- Choose one digital skill that fits your time, device and interests.
- Learn it for free, using a daily routine of 2 to 3 hours.
- Build a small portfolio of sample work with no budget.
- Set up free profiles, find your first clients and price your work with confidence.
- Deliver work, send invoices, get paid, and protect yourself from scams.
- Grow from a first small job to a steady part-time income.

How to use this course

Read one chapter at a time. Each chapter ends with a checklist. Do the actions before you move on, because the skills build on each other. If you are short of time, read the chapter in two sittings, but do not skip the exercises. Most people who stop do so because they read and never did the work.

> **Tip:**
> Keep a single notebook or a free Google Doc called 'My Digital Career'. Write your answers to every exercise there. By the end you will have your own business plan.

What this course does not promise

This course does not promise a fixed income or overnight success. Many women earn their first money within 2 to 3 months of steady effort, and some take longer. Income grows with skill, reviews and repeat clients. The route below is realistic, and it is the same route working professionals use.

CHAPTER 1

The Digital Work World

Digital work means work you do on a phone or computer for clients who may be in another city or another country. Much of it can be done from your kitchen table, in short blocks, around family duties.

Common ways digital work is paid

Model	What it means	Good for
Per project (fixed price)	You agree a price for a defined job, such as a set of 5 social media posts.	Designers, writers, editors
Per hour	You are paid for the hours you record, usually with a time tracker.	Assistants, support, transcription
Monthly retainer	A client pays a fixed amount each month for ongoing work.	Social media helpers, bookkeepers
Per task or per item	A small amount for each small item, such as a data entry row.	Beginners, but low pay

Where the work is

- Online freelance marketplaces: Upwork, Fiverr and similar sites, which connect clients worldwide.
- Direct clients you find yourself: local shops, clinics, schools, restaurants, and people in your own network.
- Community groups on Facebook and WhatsApp that post small digital jobs.
- Remote employers who hire part-time staff for support, data or content roles.

Realistic expectations for your first year

- Your first jobs will be small, and they may pay less than you hope. This is normal. Their purpose is reviews and experience.
- Clients rarely hire people with no reviews. Your first two or three jobs are about building trust, not money.
- Work comes in waves. Keep looking for clients even when you are busy, so you are never starting from zero again.
- Some offers are scams. Chapter 10 teaches you how to spot them.

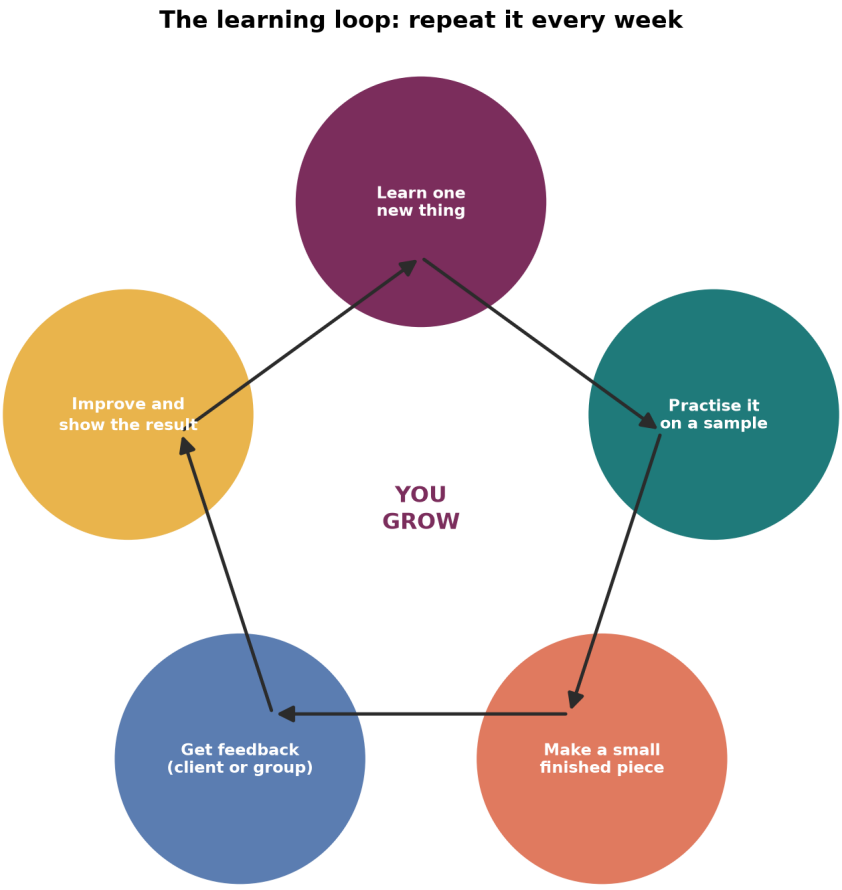


Figure 1. The learning loop. Each cycle makes your work better and your profile stronger.

CHAPTER 2

Your Starting Point: Device, Time and Safety

Before choosing a skill, take an honest inventory of what you have. You can start with a basic Android phone. A laptop helps, but it is not essential for every skill.

Step 1: Check what you already have

Item	Minimum to start	Better if you can
Device	Android or iPhone with a camera and internet	A laptop or tablet with a keyboard
Internet	Mobile data or Wi-Fi that works most days	Stable Wi-Fi for video calls
Time	45 minutes a day, 5 days a week	1.5 to 3 hours a day
Language	Reading and writing English at a simple level	Clear English for emails and clients
Space	A quiet corner where you can sit for 30 minutes	A small desk with good light

Step 2: Set up your free workspace

1. Create one Gmail address used only for work. Use a clear name, such as firstname.lastname.work@gmail.com.
2. Install WhatsApp Business (free) and fill in your business name, services and working hours.
3. Create a free Canva account and a free Google Drive. Make folders: Learning, Portfolio, Clients, Invoices.
4. Set a phone reminder for your daily learning block, and keep a notebook beside you.
5. Tell your family your work hours. A short, clear agreement prevents most interruptions.

> **Tip:**
> Use the phone's built-in Notes app or Google Keep for quick ideas. Free tools are enough for your first year.

Step 3: Digital safety basics

Your accounts are your business. Protect them from day one.

- Use a strong password of at least 12 characters, different for each service. A free password manager such as the one in your browser is fine.
- Turn on two-step verification (a code sent to your phone) for Gmail, WhatsApp and any payment account.
- Never share your one-time codes (OTP), PIN or password with anyone, even someone who says they are from a company.
- Do not install apps or files that a 'client' sends you. Ask for work through the platform or a shared Google Drive link you trust.

- Keep your phone locked with a PIN, and back up your photos and documents to Google Drive.

Family and privacy

You may decide not to show your face, home address or children in your work. A business profile needs a name, a skill and a way to contact you. It does not need your full address. Choose what you share and keep the rest private.

CHAPTER 3

Choosing Your Skill

The skill you choose matters more than anything else in this course. The right skill is one that you can learn with free resources, that you can practise in short blocks, and that people will pay for. The map below shows where each skill sits.

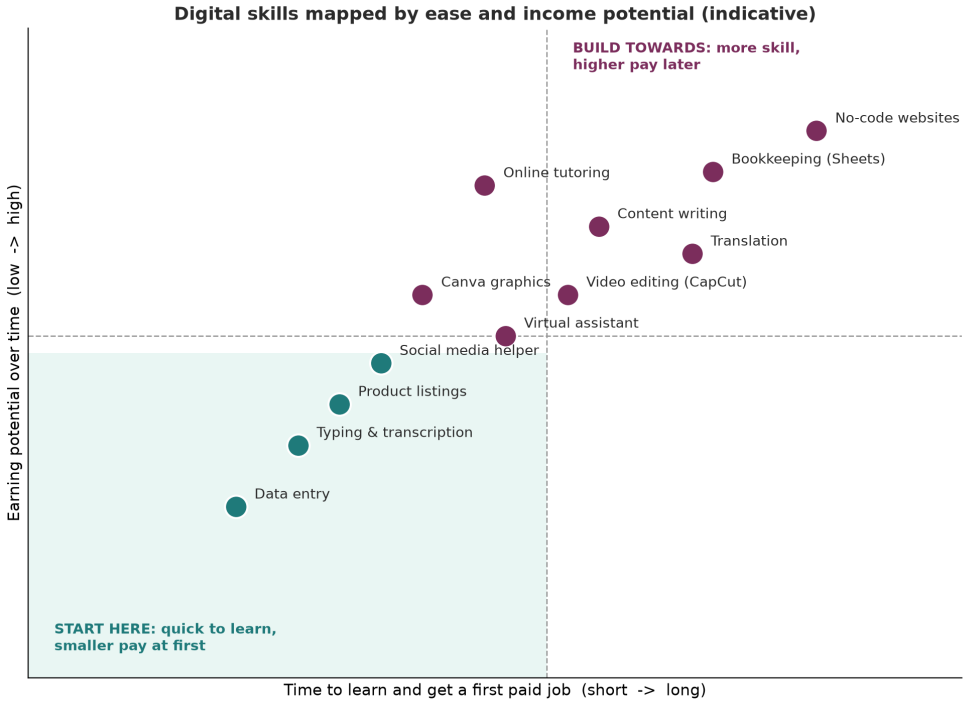


Figure 2. Skills mapped by ease of starting and income potential. Positions are indicative and differ by market.

The skills that suit beginners

Skill	What you do	Tools (free)	Time to first job
Social media helper	Create and schedule simple posts for small businesses	Canva, WhatsApp, phone	1 to 2 months
Canva graphic design	Flyers, posters, Instagram posts, menus, certificates	Canva free	1 to 3 months
Content writing	Product descriptions, blog posts, short captions	Google Docs, Grammarly free	2 to 4 months
Virtual assistant (VA)	Email, calendar, scheduling, simple research	Gmail, Calendar, Sheets	2 to 4 months
Data entry and typing	Entering data into sheets; typing and formatting	Google Sheets, Excel online	2 to 6 weeks
Video editing	Short reels, trimming, captions for businesses	CapCut on phone	2 to 4 months
Transcription and captions	Typing out audio or subtitles accurately	Free audio players, Docs	1 to 3 months
Online tutoring	Teaching school subjects or languages online	Google Meet, a whiteboard app	1 to 3 months
Bookkeeping basics	Recording sales and expenses in simple sheets	Google Sheets	3 to 6 months
No-code websites	Simple sites for small businesses	Canva websites, Google Sites	3 to 6 months

A simple way to choose

1. List the three things you enjoy most, for example writing, colours, talking to people, or organising.
2. List your available time per day and whether you have a laptop.
3. Pick two skills from the table that match both lists.
4. Spend one week on a free introductory lesson for each. Keep the one you enjoy and find easier to repeat.
5. Commit to that skill for at least 90 days before changing. Changing every week is the most common reason people stay at zero.

> **Tip:**
> Two skills can work together. For example, a social media helper who also designs in Canva can offer a complete package to a small shop.

Recommended paths

- Fastest start, with little equipment: data entry, then virtual assistance.
- Best for creative women: Canva design, then social media management.
- Best for language and writing lovers: content writing, then translation and editing.

- Best for phone-only work: video editing with CapCut, then short reel creation for shops and tutors.
- Best for organised women: bookkeeping basics with Google Sheets, then online admin support.

CHAPTER 4

Your Learning Route, Step by Step

This chapter gives you a 12-week route. It is written so that you can follow it for any skill. Replace the examples with your own skill's lessons.

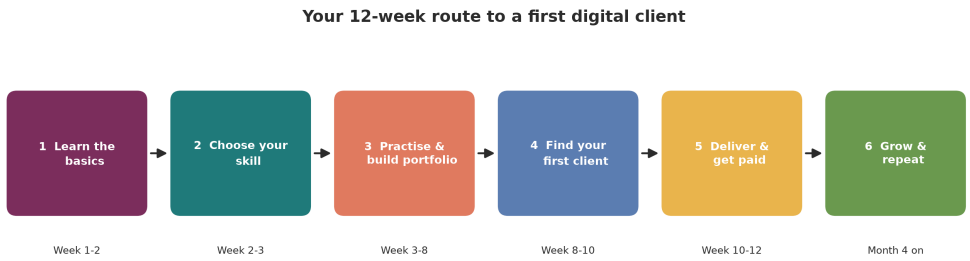


Figure 3. The 12-week route. Each stage ends with a checklist item you can tick off.

Weeks 1 to 2: Build foundations

- Learn how the internet and files work: folders, saving, sharing, and sending attachments.
- Learn basic typing and keyboard shortcuts on your device (copy, paste, undo).
- Learn to write a clear message: short sentences, a greeting, a purpose and a sign-off.
- Do the free basics of your chosen skill, such as the Canva Design School or a freeCodeCamp lesson.

Weeks 2 to 3: Learn your chosen skill

Follow one main course, not five. Watch a lesson, then immediately practise what you watched. For every hour of video, plan at least one hour of practice. Keep a short log of what you did each day.

Weeks 3 to 8: Practise and build a portfolio

This is the core of the course. Make at least six sample pieces of work. Each sample should be for an imaginary or real small business. Chapter 5 explains exactly how.

Weeks 8 to 10: Find your first clients

Start outreach once you have three samples and a basic profile. Follow Chapter 7 for the message templates.

Weeks 10 to 12: Deliver and get paid

Your first job should be small and clearly defined. Agree the scope in writing, deliver on time, ask for a review, and send an invoice (Chapter 9).

Your weekly routine

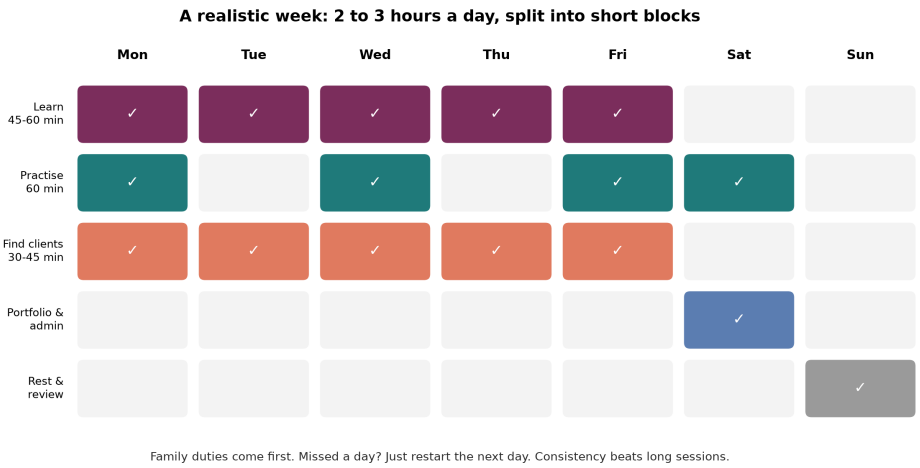


Figure 4. A realistic week. Adjust the days to your family routine.

Tip:
Measure progress by output, not hours. At the end of each week, write down what you made and what you learned. Three finished samples are worth more than fifteen hours of watching videos.

- ■ I have chosen one main skill and written it down.
- ■ I have a learning routine and a weekly plan in my calendar.
- ■ I have completed the foundations lessons.
- ■ I have made at least one practice piece and shown it to someone for feedback.

CHAPTER 5

Building Your Portfolio with No Budget

A portfolio is your proof of skill. Clients buy trust, and a portfolio is how you show it. You do not need paid work to make one. You need six to eight strong samples that look like real jobs.

How to create samples without clients

- Choose three imaginary or real small businesses: a bakery, a tuition centre and a clinic are common and easy to imagine.
- For each business, create the kind of work they would need: a flyer, a set of Instagram posts, a short reel cover, or a product list.
- Ask one or two local shop owners if you may redesign their post for free, in exchange for a review and a credit. Get written permission before you publish their name or logo.
- Make each sample look finished: a clear headline, a single main image, and a call to action.

Where to host your portfolio for free

- A single Google Drive folder shared as 'anyone with the link can view'.
- A free Canva design presented as a link, or a free Canva website.
- A free LinkedIn featured section or a free Behance profile.
- A WhatsApp Business catalogue, which clients can open on their phone.

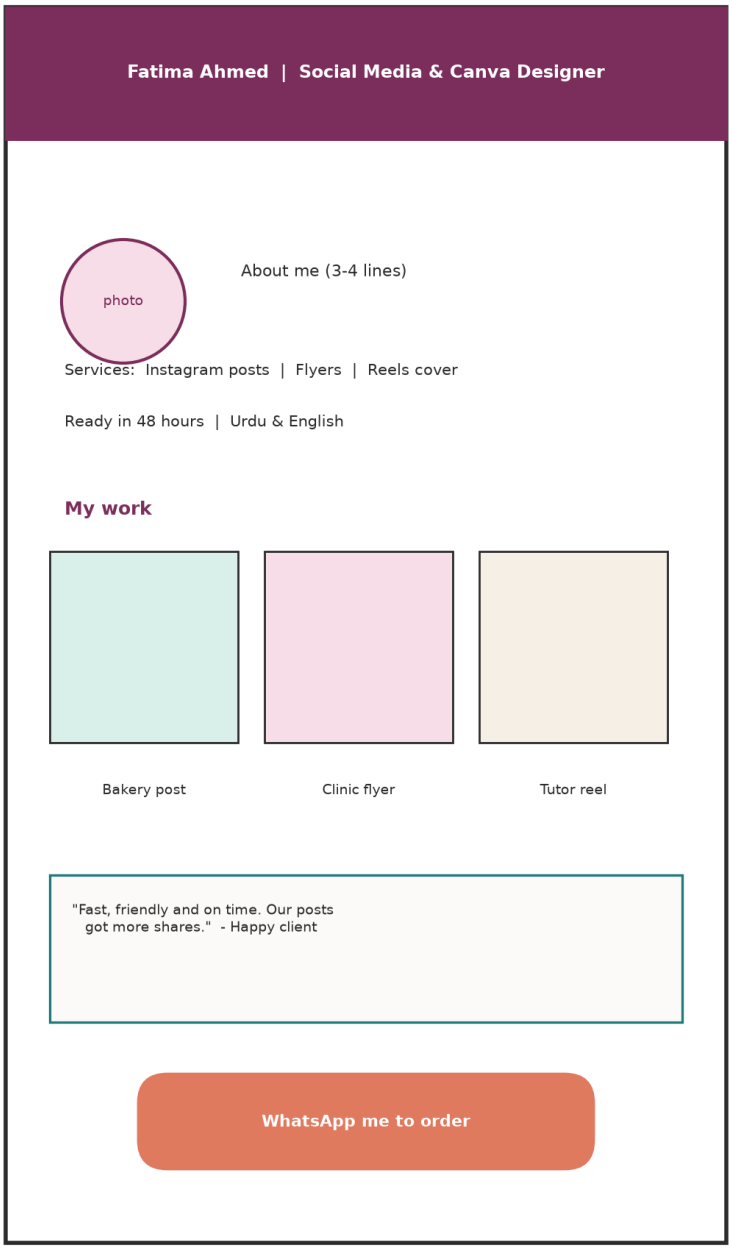


Figure 5. A simple mobile portfolio layout: name and skill at the top, your work in the middle, a review, and one clear button to contact you.

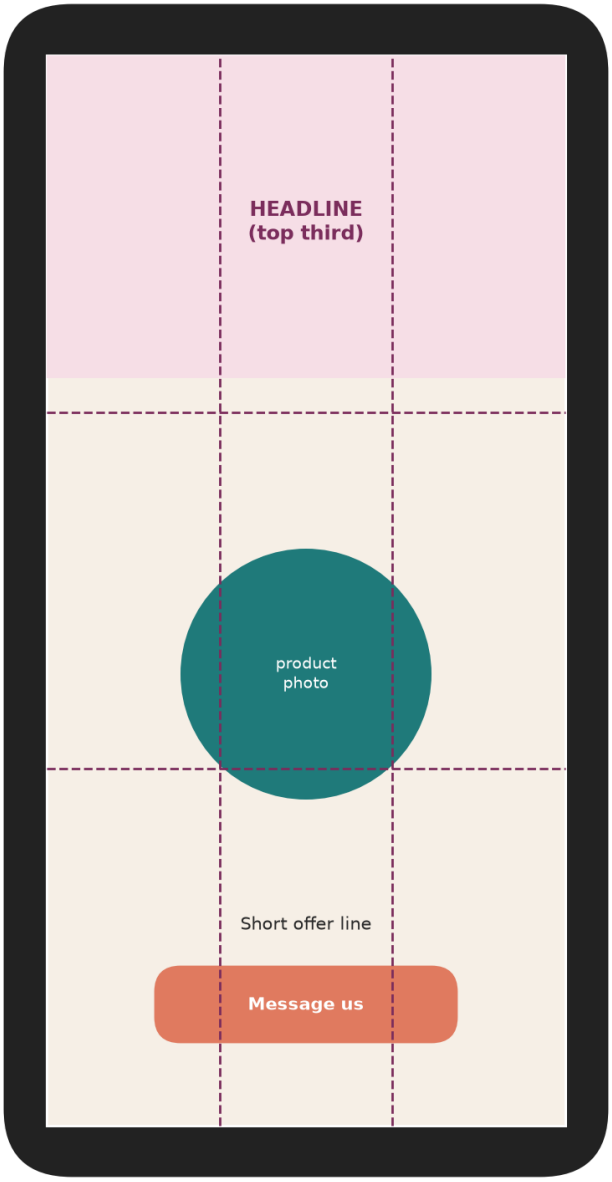
What a good portfolio page includes

- Your name, skill and one line on what you offer.
- Three to six samples, each with a short caption that explains the problem and the result.
- One review, even a short one from a friend who saw your work (state that it is a practice project).
- A clear way to contact you, such as a WhatsApp button.
- Your working hours, turnaround time and languages you work in.

Tip:
Never use a sample you did not create, and never claim a result that did not happen. Clients check, and a single false claim can end your career before it starts.

Quality rules

- Use the rule of thirds: place the main subject where the lines cross, not in the exact centre.
- Use no more than three colours and two fonts in one design.
- Leave empty space around text. Crowded designs look amateur.
- Check spelling twice. Read the text aloud once.
- Test your portfolio on a phone. Most clients will open it there first.



Put the main subject where the dashed lines cross.

Figure 6. The rule of thirds on a phone post. The headline sits in the top third, the product in the middle, and the button at the bottom.

CHAPTER 6

Setting Up Your Online Profiles

Your profile is your shop window. Clients decide in about thirty seconds whether to read further. Make those seconds count.

The profile formula

1. Headline: what you do, for whom, in one line. Example: 'Canva designer for small food businesses, Urdu and English'.
2. Photo: a clear, friendly, recent photo. Good light from a window is enough. If you prefer privacy, use a simple logo or a tidy graphic.
3. Summary: three short paragraphs. What you do, who you help, and what the client gets.
4. Samples: link your portfolio and pin your best three pieces.
5. Availability: hours per day, turnaround time, and the languages you work in.

Freelance marketplaces

Platform	Best for	Things to know
Upwork	Writing, admin, data, design, VA work	Uses 'connects' to bid on jobs; start by bidding on small, clearly written jobs.
Fiverr	Packaged services with fixed prices	You create 'gigs' with set prices; good for designers and video editors.
LinkedIn	Professional clients and employers	Build a profile and post short updates about your work.
Facebook and WhatsApp groups	Local and regional small jobs	Read the group rules; never pay to join a 'job group'.

> **Tip:**
> Check the current terms of any platform before you join, including fees, withdrawal options and country availability. Terms change, and this course cannot guarantee them.

Your first marketplace gig or profile

Start with one platform, not all of them. Complete the profile to 100 percent, and bid or apply to ten carefully chosen jobs in your first month. Quality beats quantity: a short, personal proposal that answers the client's exact question wins more often than a generic copy-paste message.

CHAPTER 7

Finding Clients

Finding clients is a skill you can learn, and it is mostly about consistent, polite outreach. Most beginners stop after a few silent replies. The funnel below shows why you should keep going.



Figure 7. A client-hunting funnel. Numbers are illustrative. Your ratios will improve with practice.

Where to look

- Local businesses with weak social media: salons, bakeries, clinics, tuition centres, boutiques, restaurants.
- Friends, relatives and neighbours who run a small business or know one.
- Former colleagues and classmates who now work in companies.
- Marketplace job posts that match your skill and budget.
- Community and professional groups where people ask for help.

Message templates

Personalise every message. Mention one specific thing you noticed about their business. Keep it under 80 words.

Template 1: a local shop
'Hello [Name], I am [Your name], a Canva designer who helps small food businesses with Instagram posts. I noticed your bakery posts do not show your new menu. I made a sample post for you (no obligation). Shall I send it?'

Template 2: a former contact
'Hi [Name], hope you are well. I have started offering [skill] for small businesses from home. If you know anyone who needs [specific help], I would be grateful for an introduction. Happy to help you too, anytime.'

Template 3: a marketplace proposal
'Hello, I have done [similar task] for [type of client]. I can deliver [specific result] by [date]. Could you share your brand colours and the main message you want? I will send a draft within 24 hours.'

Follow-up without being pushy

1. Wait three working days after your first message.
2. Send one short follow-up that adds value, such as a tip or a free idea.
3. If there is still no reply after a second follow-up, stop and move on. Politeness protects your reputation.

Your weekly client-hunting target

Send 15 to 20 personal messages a week, record them in a simple sheet with the date, name, reply and next step, and review the sheet on Friday. Recording is what turns outreach into a system.

- ■ I have a free sheet to track every contact.
- ■ I have sent at least 20 personalised messages this week.
- ■ I have a standard follow-up plan for every contact.
- ■ I have offered at least one free sample to a potential client.

CHAPTER 8

Pricing, Proposals and Negotiation

Many beginners underprice their work out of fear. Underpricing attracts difficult clients, leaves you exhausted, and makes it hard to raise prices later. Set a price you can defend.

A simple way to price your first jobs

1. Estimate the hours the job will take, including revisions. Add one revision round to every price.
2. Multiply by a fair hourly rate. Check the rates that similar freelancers charge on the same marketplace, and start in the lower middle of that range.
3. Add a small buffer of 10 to 20 percent for unexpected work.
4. Compare with the value to the client. A sales post that brings customers is worth more than a plain design.

Your first three jobs may be discounted to build reviews. State this clearly: 'This is an introductory price for my first two reviews.' Then raise the price for the next client.

What a proposal must contain

- The client's problem, in their own words.
- What you will deliver, in clear, countable items.
- The timeline, with a delivery date.
- The price, the payment method and the number of revisions included.
- A reason to choose you: one relevant sample or result.

Handling negotiation

- Do not drop the price first. Ask what budget the client has in mind.
- If the price is too high, reduce the scope rather than the rate. For example: 'I can do 4 posts instead of 8 for that budget.'
- Say no politely when the offer is below your minimum. A clear no is better than a resentful yes.
- Put every agreement in writing, even in a short chat message.

> **Tip:**
> Keep a list of your own minimum rate per hour. Decide it before you talk to clients, so you are not pressured in the moment.

CHAPTER 9

Delivering Work, Communication and Getting Paid

Delivery decides whether a client returns, leaves a review, and refers you to others. Professional habits are simple, and you can start them today.

The delivery routine

1. Confirm the brief in writing: what, for whom, the deadline, the format and the number of revisions.
2. Work in short steps and share a draft early. A rough draft at 50 percent saves a lot of rework.
3. Deliver the final files in a clear format (PNG or PDF for designs, DOCX or Google Docs for text, MP4 for video).
4. Send a short message: what you delivered, where the files are, and what you need from the client next.
5. Ask for a review and feedback after the job is accepted.

Communication habits

- Reply within one working day, even if the reply is 'received, I will send the draft on Thursday'.
- Use a fixed daily time to answer messages, so you are not always on your phone.
- Keep important decisions in writing. Use the platform's chat or email for anything involving money.

Invoices

An invoice is a simple document that asks for payment. It protects you and tells the client exactly what to pay. Use a free Google Docs template or Canva template, number each invoice in order, and keep a copy in your Invoices folder.

Date: 07/11/2026

Your name / business | phone | email

Bill to:

Client name / business / address

Description	Qty	Amount
Instagram post design	1	PKR 1,500
Flyer (A5, 2 designs)	2	PKR 2,400
Reel cover	1	PKR 800
Revision (1 round)	1	Free

Total: PKR 4,700

Payment: bank / mobile wallet / Payoneer details

Payment due within 7 days. Thank you for your business!

Figure 8. A simple invoice layout. Include your name, the client's name, the items, the total, the payment details and the due date.

How money reaches you

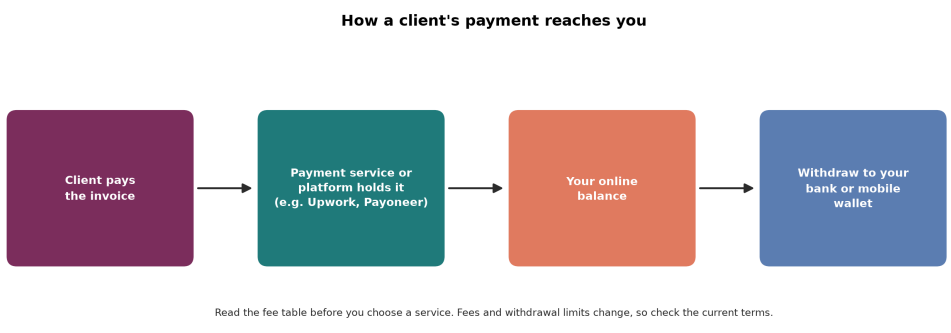


Figure 9. The usual route for money from a client to you. Check the fees and the withdrawal method before you accept your first payment.

- Marketplace clients pay the platform, which releases money to your balance after the job is marked complete.
- Direct clients may pay by bank transfer, mobile wallet or a payment service. Share only the payment details you have chosen and set up yourself.
- Track every payment in your sheet: date, client, amount, method and fee. Good records make tax filing and budgeting much easier.

> **Tip:**
> Never accept payment in a way that gives you no record. Keep a copy of every receipt, screenshot and transfer confirmation.

CHAPTER 10

Staying Safe From Scams

Digital work attracts scammers who target people who are new and eager. Learn the warning signs and you will avoid most problems.

Red flags

Warning sign	What it usually means
You are asked to pay a fee to get a job, join a team, or unlock payment	A scam. Real employers do not charge you to start work.
Very high pay for very easy work, often with a 'quick start' bonus	A scam, often a fake cheque or overpayment trick.
You are sent a cheque or payment and asked to return part of it	A fraud. The original payment will bounce later.
The client wants to move the chat off the platform immediately	They want to avoid the platform's protection. Be careful.
You are asked for your OTP, PIN, password or a code sent to your phone	Never share it. Real staff never ask.
You are asked to download an unknown app or open a file to 'verify' work	This can install malware or steal your data.
Vague job description, no company name, no way to verify	Walk away. Ask for a verifiable company name and website.

Before you accept any new client

- ■ I have checked the client's profile, reviews and history on the platform.
- ■ I have a written brief and a clear price before I start.
- ■ I have not been asked to pay anything to start work.
- ■ The payment method is one I have set up myself, and I can see it in my account.
- ■ I can say no without feeling pressure.

If something goes wrong

- Stop communicating, save screenshots, and report the job or user to the platform.
- Tell a trusted friend or family member before you take any action.
- If money was taken from you, contact your bank or payment provider immediately and follow their steps.

CHAPTER 11

Balancing Home and Work, and Growing Your Career

A digital career works best when it fits your life. Your family, your health and your rest matter more than any single job. This chapter helps you protect your time and grow your income step by step.

Protecting your time

- Set fixed working hours and announce them to your family and clients.
- Use a timer for short focused blocks, such as 45 minutes of work followed by a 10-minute break.
- Keep one place for work. When the laptop or the work notebook is closed, the job is done for the day.
- Say no to work that does not fit your hours, even if it pays well.

Growing from a first job to a career

Stage	Typical focus	Goal
Stage 1: First 3 months	Build samples, get first 2 to 3 reviews	Trust and proof
Stage 2: Months 3 to 6	Raise prices slightly, ask for repeat work	A few regular clients
Stage 3: Months 6 to 12	Offer a package, such as monthly social media care	Predictable monthly income
Stage 4: Year 2 onwards	Specialise, train others, or build a small team	Steady part-time or full-time career

Keep learning, one skill at a time

Once your first skill earns, add one related skill every six months. A designer can learn basic video editing. A writer can learn basic SEO. A VA can learn bookkeeping. Each new skill raises your value to existing clients.

Build a small network

- Join one or two professional groups and answer questions honestly.
- Share something useful each week: a tip, a before-and-after sample, or a lesson learned.
- Thank clients publicly for reviews, with their permission.

> **Tip:**
> Write down one income goal and one time goal for each quarter. Review them every three months. Adjust, then continue.

CHAPTER 12

Your 90-Day Action Plan

Use this plan as your final checklist. Each week has one main goal. Tick it off in your notebook.

Week	Main goal	Done when
1	Choose your skill and set up free tools	Gmail, WhatsApp Business, Canva and Drive are ready
2	Complete the foundations and first skill lessons	You have finished the first course or module
3 to 4	Make your first two samples	Two samples are saved in your portfolio folder
5 to 6	Make four more samples and build the portfolio page	Six samples and a portfolio link are ready
7	Set up profiles and your tracking sheet	Profile is complete and the sheet is live
8 to 9	Send 15 to 20 messages a week	At least 40 messages are sent and logged
10	Prepare pricing and a proposal template	Your rate card and proposal template are saved
11	Deliver your first job	Client accepts the work and you send an invoice
12	Ask for a review and plan the next 90 days	A review is received and the next plan is written

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Freelancer	A self-employed person who sells work to clients
Gig	A service listed for sale on a platform such as Fiverr
Portfolio	A collection of your best work shown to clients
Proposal	A written offer that describes the work, timeline and price
Invoice	A document requesting payment for completed work
Retainer	A fixed monthly payment for ongoing work
OTP	A one-time password sent to your phone; never share it
Funnel	The steps from first contact to a paying client
Review	A rating and comment left by a client after a job

A final word: your first job is a turning point, not a finish line. Each skill you learn, each sample you finish and each message you send adds up. Start today with one small action.